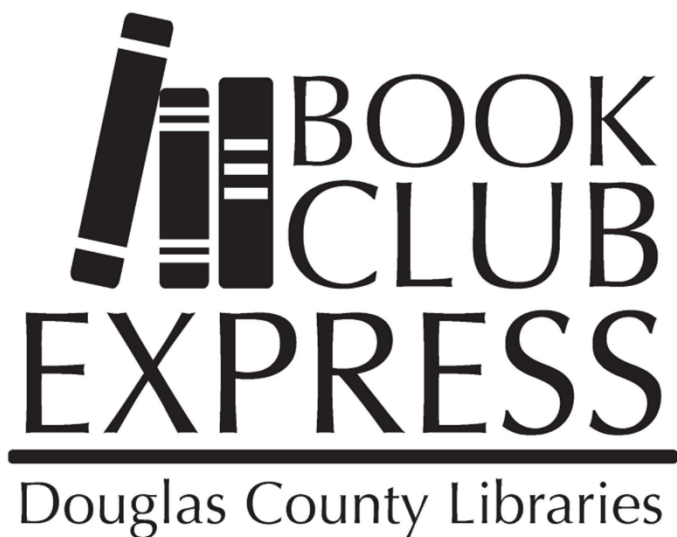




Wayward Girls
by Susan Wiggs

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Discussion Questions

- 1) At the start of the book, we learn that Mairin “just wanted to be a person of consequence living a life that mattered. A person making her mark on the world.” What did that look like for a young woman in 1960s Buffalo? Do you think she’s achieved her dreams by the end of the book?
- 2) What did you make of the scene where Mairin’s mother and stepfather drop her off at the Good Shepherd? What about the sudden revelation that both Mairin’s mother and stepfather had done their own time in similar Catholic institutions?
- 3) When we first meet Sister Bernadette, Angela says, “Imagine being here as an inmate, and then deciding to stay.” Why did Sister Bernadette choose to spend her life with the Sisters of Charity, even knowing what was happening at the Good Shepherd? How does she evolve over the course of the book? Do you think she regrets her choices? Should she?
- 4) Why do the wayward girls cut their hair? Does that act send them down the path that ultimately leads to their escape?
- 5) Sister Gerard defends her embezzling to Sister Bernadette by telling her, “The diocese has enough we fail to secure our future, what will become of we’re old, no one will take care of us unless we act now to plan for our future.” Is that a valid justification? Are the nuns themselves also vulnerable within the Church’s power structure, even as they abuse the girls in their care?
- 6) At Heyday Farm, after escaping the Good Shepherd, Mairin “realized there were all kinds of ways to be wayward. And all kinds of ways to be lost.” Does that realization help her move on? Do the many different people who wash up at the farm reflect something larger about American society in the Vietnam era?
- 7) When Mairin learns the truth about her mother’s past, she reflects: “Now that she finally understood what had made Mam this way, she realized her mother was a wayward girl. Like her.” Did that revelation change how you felt about Mrs. Davis, or her choice to send Mairin to the Good Shepherd? What did it change for Mairin?
- 8) In the present-day storyline, we learn what’s become of each of the wayward girls in the decades since their escape. How were you affected by those discoveries?
- 9) Two of Mairin’s friends, Janice Dunn and Kevin Doyle, became a nun and a priest. Do they represent a different side of the Catholic Church than the one the wayward girls experienced at the Good Shepherd? Are they able to change from inside the institution?
- 10) Did the wayward girls gain anything by visiting Sisters Rotrude and Bernadette in their retirement home? How would you have handled that encounter if you’d been in their shoes?
- 11) Ultimately, do the wayward girls receive justice for what they suffered at the Good Shepherd? What else, if anything, do you think they and other victims deserved? Do you know of similar injustices that have come to light in your own community?

Author Interview

JENNIFER VIDO: What sparked the idea for WAYWARD GIRLS? Was there one moment that made you say, I have to write this?

SUSAN WIGGS: I grew up in a small town in western New York, not far from Buffalo, but we moved overseas when I was a child. I never went back until 2021, when my big brother and I embarked on a journey to revisit our childhood haunts.

When we visited the church of our youth, vivid memories of Jon as an altar boy flooded back—especially the time his sleeve caught fire from the incense thurible. You might notice a dramatized version of this incident early in the novel!

This moment sparked a deeper exploration into the impact of the Catholic Church in the 60s and 70s. My research led me to a forbidding stone complex at 485 Best Street in Buffalo that had once been a Magdalene Laundry—a place where “wayward girls” were sent to be “reformed” by strict nuns. Teenage girls were forced into slave labor and some delivered babies without proper medical care—babies that were sometimes stolen from them and placed for adoption. Though vaguely aware of the “laundries” in Ireland, I was shocked to learn they existed throughout the U.S. as well.

It was one of those “Oh boy, here we goooo” moments a writer experiences (if she’s lucky) that inspires her to write the book.

JV: This story is set in the 60s. What do you love most about writing historical fiction?

SW: My favorite thing about writing historical fiction is when I stumble across an “Easter egg” while doing research. For example, in Wayward Girls, I was reading up on the late 60s, and I came across the fact that in 1967, there was a race riot in Buffalo that was so intense that baseball star Jackie Robinson was sent to help quell it. And in 1969, Niagara Falls STOPPED. Dried up. The nuns in the book deemed it a miracle, but of course there’s another explanation. These details bring the story to life and—in the case of the “miracle” at the Falls, send the story shooting off in a new direction.

JV: How did you balance real-life inspiration with your imagination when creating these characters?

SW: I aimed for my cast of characters to be as diverse, human, quirky, flawed, and irrepressible as people in real life. (Except Flynn. Flynn is perfect.) They aren’t based on real people, but they share endearing, exasperating, and deeply human traits with real people. I hope I succeeded in making each girl at the Good Shepherd, the reform school in the book, shine in her own unique way—Mairin, who is impulsive and fierce, Angela—sensitive and vulnerable, passionate Odessa, brilliant and focused Helen, Janice the snitch, and childlike Kay. Together, they seem like a band of misfits, but in their shared goal to survive, they are a sisterhood.

JV: This book is about friendship in really tough circumstances. What do you think makes a strong friendship last?

SW: This is one of the central questions of the book. Some friendships are forged by fire, when people face intense circumstances together, and an indelible bond forms. The story spans 50 years, and yet when the women find each other again, they revert to their teenage selves, as if no time at all has passed.

JV: How did you stay hopeful while writing about some difficult moments?

SW: Ah, good question. This book took longer than usual for me—I'm usually a pretty fast writer. That's probably because I had to proceed with extra sensitivity around these issues. I wanted to make sure I didn't whitewash things, but at the same time, my natural instinct is to move toward a place of hope.

JV: What do you hope readers feel when they turn the last page?

SW: I hope they've felt something deep and learned something lasting. Jodi Picoult mentioned that the book is not just a moment in time, but a cautionary tale for today's world. The way we treat our girls will define us as a society, and we need to do a better job.

JV: What's one thing you learned while researching or writing this book that stuck with you?

SW: I can't stop thinking about how powerful a person's survival instinct is, when they're up against a wall. The real survivors of the Good Shepherd are still with us, speaking out against the abuses they suffered.

JV: If you could sit down with any one of your characters, who would it be and what would you want to ask them?

SW: I'd want to kick back with Helen May, because she led such a singular life. Also, the guy she ended up marrying is dreamy, so I'd want to hear about their love story!

JV: How did you celebrate when you finished WAYWARD GIRLS? And, what's next for you?

SW: Well, after the most holy ritual Cleaning of the Writing Studio, I immediately jumped in the camper and drove to Texas to see the total eclipse of 2024 (April 8). On the road, I read the entire first draft to Jerry. He's an amazing listener and I made a lot of changes to the story based on how it sounded as I read all 130,000 words aloud!

Next up is...something old and something new. That's all I can say at this point. But currently the next book is my favorite. Because I haven't spoiled it by writing the ending!

JV: What's the best way for readers to stay connected with you?

SW: Instagram, Facebook, Bluesky, Threads, or better yet, subscribe to my newsletter on my website!

Author Biography

Susan Wiggs's life is all about family, friends...and fiction. She lives at the water's edge on an island in Puget Sound, and in good weather, she commutes to her writers' group in a 21-foot motorboat. She's been featured in the national media, including NPR, PRI, and USA Today, has given programs for the US Embassies in Buenos Aires and Montevideo, and is a popular speaker locally, nationally, internationally, and on the high seas.

From the very start, her writings have illuminated the everyday dramas of ordinary people facing extraordinary circumstances. Her books celebrate the power of love, the timeless bonds of family and the fascinating nuances of human nature. Today, she is an international best-selling, award-winning author, with millions of copies of her books in print in numerous countries and languages. According to Publishers Weekly, Wiggs writes with "refreshingly honest emotion," and the Salem Statesman Journal adds that she is "one of our best observers of stories of the heart [who] knows how to capture emotion on virtually every page of every book." Booklist characterizes her books as "real and true and unforgettable."

The author is a former teacher, a Harvard graduate, an avid hiker, an amateur photographer, a good skier and terrible golfer, yet her favorite form of exercise is curling up with a good book. She lives on an island in Puget Sound, where she divides her time between sleeping and waking.

Reviews

Susan Wiggs is known for novels with relatable characters and narratives that hook the reader from the start. Her latest book, *WAYWARD GIRLS*, is historical fiction at its best. In this gripping story, we meet young girls who were forced to leave school, their homes and their families to work at a Catholic laundry masquerading as a charity home for wayward girls in New York.

When Mairin's father died, she was only 10 years old. Her mother --- a staunch Irish Catholic who was afraid of not being able to provide for Mairin and her older brother, Liam --- remarried quickly. Her choice was unfortunate, and within a few years, Mairin's stepfather seemed interested in being more than a stepfather to her. Liam intervened and beat him. He then taught Mairin self-defense, but he was drafted in the Vietnam War and was going to leave soon. Mairin would be unprotected. Her stepfather didn't want her around because she wasn't going to be an easy victim, and her mother was worried about her safety.

"...historical fiction at its best.... I definitely will continue to think about this book because of the characters and the shocking historical facts."

Their answer was to put Mairin in the Home of the Good Shepherd, a Catholic institution that took in wayward girls to educate them and teach them morals and manners. However, no one outside the walls of the building knew that no education was going on there. The girls did not study reading or math, were not up on current events, and did not enter any classrooms. Instead, they worked long hours in the laundry, always behind locked doors. They were severely punished for the slightest infraction, fed poorly (while the nuns ate lavish meals), and isolated from everything outside the walls.

Mairin was spunky and determined to escape. Time after time, harsh punishment after severe beating, she kept trying, planning and thinking about how to leave. She finally did succeed, but the secrets, the cruelty and the depredations of living enslaved left their marks on her. And while she was able to build a happy life with a loving family, she always felt the weight of the secrets she carried with her from her hidden past.

While Mairin is the main character, we also meet and grow close to three other girls who bonded with her there and helped in the escape. When they meet again, decades after their imprisonment, they decide to get justice.

While immediately engrossing and informative (I didn't know that adopted people needed a pre-adoption birth certificate in order to get a passport), this book is also difficult to read at times. The events that occur and the cruelty of life behind the church walls are painful to read about. And knowing they are based on real events makes it even harder to stomach. That such horrors were inflicted on girls with no family or who had been mistreated is unconscionable and heartrending. And that these things were done under the auspices of the Catholic Church is even more terrible.

But Wiggs presents us with girls filled with fortitude, resourceful young ladies who become women to be respected. *WAYWARD GIRLS* is about surviving and friendship, determination and courage, and

ultimately getting justice. Fans of Susan Wiggs' work also will appreciate a few tongue-in-cheek references to at least one of her previous novels. I definitely will continue to think about this book because of the characters and the shocking historical facts. I also plan to use it as a future book club read.

Read-Alikes

The Lost Girls of Willowbrook by Ellen Marie Wiseman

Six years after her twin sister's death, 16-year-old Sage discovers a shocking secret, her sister didn't die, she was committed to Willowbrook State School until she recently went missing, and, determined to find her, Sage walks through its doors, which changes her life in ways she never could have imagined.

Small Things Like These by Claire Keegan

It is 1985 in a small Irish town. During the weeks leading up to Christmas, Bill Furlong, a coal merchant and family man faces into his busiest season. Early one morning, while delivering an order to the local convent, Bill makes a discovery which forces him to confront both his past and the complicit silences of a town controlled by the church.